

DISADVANTAGES FOR BONUS FEATS

A codified system allowing starting characters to take a bonus feat in exchange for a significant, mechanically binding disadvantage. Inspired by classic TTRPG flaw systems, these options provide deep roleplay hooks alongside concrete rules.

Cognitive & Psychological

Simple-Minded

Roleplay: The character struggles with complex concepts, takes metaphors literally, or has a terrible memory. You can choose a specific flavor of simplicity (e.g., incredibly gullible, uneducated, or instinct-driven).

Mechanics: You suffer a **-1 penalty to Intelligence**. Additionally, you have **Disadvantage on Intelligence (Investigation) and Intelligence (History) checks**.

Fractured Psyche

Roleplay: The character struggles with reality. They might hear whispers, suffer from intense paranoia, or see hallucinatory overlays on the physical world.

Mechanics: You have **Disadvantage on saving throws against the Frightened and Charmed conditions**, as well as against any spell from the **Illusion** school.

Severe Phobia

Roleplay: A debilitating terror regarding a specific, moderately common element (e.g., Fire, Darkness, Beasts, Undead, Heights).

Mechanics: When you roll initiative, if your phobia trigger is visible or heavily present within 30 feet, you must succeed on a **DC 13 Wisdom saving throw**. On a failure, you begin combat with the **Frightened** condition for 1 minute. You can repeat the save at the end of each of your turns to end the effect.

Craven

Roleplay: Self-preservation completely overrides heroism. The character is hesitant to enter the fray and prefers to let others take the first hit.

Mechanics: You have **Disadvantage on Initiative rolls**. Furthermore, you cannot take the Dash action if that movement would bring you closer to a hostile creature.

Compulsive Greed

Roleplay: The character cannot resist hoarding wealth. They will aggressively haggle, obsess over loot splitting, and take unnecessary risks for a shiny object.

Mechanics: You have **Disadvantage on Wisdom (Insight) checks** during financial negotiations. If you are out of combat and spot valuable, seemingly unguarded treasure, you must make a **DC 13 Wisdom saving throw** or be compelled to immediately approach and attempt to secure it.

Physical

Clouded Sight

Roleplay: The character's eyes are milky, heavily scarred, or permanently covered. They must rely entirely on their other senses to navigate the world.

Mechanics: You suffer from the **Blinded** condition permanently. Offset: You gain **Blindsight out to a range of 30 feet**. Beyond 30 feet, you automatically fail any ability check that requires sight, and attacks from outside that radius have Advantage against you.

Grotesque Visage

Roleplay: The character is heavily mutated, severely scarred, or bears a supernaturally unnerving aura. NPCs will instinctively cross the street or treat them with hostility and suspicion.

Mechanics: You have **Disadvantage on Charisma (Persuasion) and Charisma (Performance) checks**. Because of your terrifying appearance, you may choose to have **Advantage on Charisma (Intimidation) checks** using Strength or Charisma.

Missing Limb: Arm

Roleplay: Whether from a past battle, an accident, or birth, the character operates with only one functional arm.

Mechanics: You cannot use weapons with the **Two-Handed** property, you cannot benefit from a **Shield**, and you cannot engage in **Two-Weapon Fighting**. Any mundane task that strictly requires two hands (like tying a complex knot) is made with Disadvantage.

Missing Limb: Leg

Roleplay: The character uses a peg leg, a crutch, or heavy bracing to move around, making them slower and less agile.

Mechanics: Your base walking speed is **reduced by 10 feet**. You have **Disadvantage on Dexterity (Acrobatics) checks**, and standing up from the Prone condition consumes your entire movement for that turn, rather than half.

Social & Behavioral

Hunted / Wanted

Roleplay: The character has a massive bounty on their head, or a powerful faction is actively tracking them. They must constantly look over their shoulder.

Mechanics: You have **Disadvantage on Charisma (Deception) and Charisma (Persuasion) checks** when dealing with guards, bounty hunters, or officials. Once per adventure (at the DM's discretion), your pursuers will interrupt a rest or ambush the party.

Vow of Absolute Truth

Roleplay: Whether due to a rigid oath, a fey curse, or a fundamental psychological block, the character is entirely incapable of telling a deliberate lie.

Mechanics: You automatically **fail any Charisma (Deception) checks**. Furthermore, you have **Disadvantage on Charisma (Persuasion) checks** if the negotiation requires you to strategically omit important, relevant facts.

Overwhelming Arrogance

Roleplay: The character believes they are unequivocally the smartest, strongest, or most important person in the room. They refuse help and look down on others.

Mechanics: You cannot benefit from the **Help action** given by allies on any ability check. Additionally, if an NPC insults or challenges your pride, you must succeed on a **DC 13 Charisma saving throw** or be compelled to escalate the situation aggressively.

Biological & Constitution

Chronic Frailty

Roleplay: The character suffers from a lingering illness, a weak heart, or just a fundamentally poor constitution. They tire easily and heal slowly.

Mechanics: You suffer a **-1 penalty to Constitution**. When you finish a Long Rest, you only regain a number of spent Hit Dice equal to **a quarter of your total Hit Dice** (minimum of 1), rather than half.

Chemical Dependency

Roleplay: The character is addicted to a specific substance (a fantasy narcotic, special tea, or alcohol). They need it to function.

Mechanics: You must consume a dose of your substance every 24 hours. If you do not, you gain **1 level of Exhaustion**. This exhaustion cannot be removed by resting; it can only be removed by consuming the substance or via a Lesser Restoration spell.

Heavy-Footed / Clumsy

Roleplay: The character is notoriously loud, uncoordinated, and constantly stepping on dry twigs or knocking over tankards.

Mechanics: You have **Disadvantage on Dexterity (Stealth) and Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) checks**. Furthermore, if you roll a 1 on an attack roll, you accidentally drop your weapon or spellcasting focus.

Mystical & Luck-Based

Jinxed / Unlucky

Roleplay: The universe just seems to have it out for this character. Ropes snap when they climb them, and gusts of wind blow out their torches.

Mechanics: You hand the DM a "Jinx Token" at the start of every session. At any point during the session, the DM can spend this token to force you to **reroll a successful attack roll, saving throw, or ability check** and take the lower result.

Magical Susceptibility

Roleplay: The character's soul or physical form acts as a sponge for hostile magic. They are uniquely vulnerable to the arcane.

Mechanics: Choose two elemental damage types (e.g., Fire and Lightning). You have **Vulnerability** to those damage types. (Alternatively, you have Disadvantage on all saving throws against spells of a specific, common school of magic).

Restless Spirit (Insomnia)

Roleplay: The character is plagued by nightmares, haunted by ghosts, or fundamentally incapable of deep sleep.

Mechanics: Whenever you take a Long Rest, you must roll a **DC 10 Constitution saving throw**. On a failure, you gain the benefits of a Short Rest instead of a Long Rest. Another character can spend an hour of their rest using medicine/magic to soothe you, granting Advantage on the save.